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The English tenses

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The simple present:

It is used to speak about a repeated action, a habit, a routine, and a general truth.

The structure: S+V (he, she, it + V+S)

The tense indicators: always, usually, often, sometimes, rarely, every (day, month, year…)

The present progressive:

It is used to speak about an action taking place now, at the time of speaking, or to speak about a temporary action that has a short duration.

The structure: S+ TO BE + V+ ING

The tense indicators: now, at the moment, in these days, at this time, look!

The present perfect:

It is used to speak about an action that started in the past and continues up to the present, or an action that stared in the past with a present consequence. It is the most commonly used tense.

The structure: S + has/have+ past participle

The tense indicators:

For+ period: he has been a pupil **for 11 years.**

Since+ date: he has been a pupil **since 2005**

Ever? have you ever been to the United States?

Never: No, I **have never been** to the States.

Already: I **have already visited** many countries of the world.

Just: He **has just come** home from work.

Recently: She **has recently obtained** her degree.

Almost: I **have almost finished** reading the book, only about ten pages are left.

Yet: I **have not finished** my exams, **yet.**

So far: I have **so far**, visited many countries of the world.

Up to now: up to now, the score is still the same.

How long: (always in question form) **(for) How long** have you been in Tunisia?

The future:

It is used to indicate that an action is going to take place in the future. It has no relationship with the present or the past.

The structure: S+ will+ V in the bare infinitive (without "to")

The tense indicators: tomorrow, soon, in the future, to hope, next (week, month, year…) a future date (2050…)

The simple past:

It is used to speak about an action that happened in the past with no relation ever with the present or the future.

The structure: S +V+ ed / irregular past

The tense indicators: yesterday; ago, last (week, month, year…) in the past, when, a past date (1950…) once, once upon a time, then, at that time, to wish

The past progressive:

It is used to speak about an action in progress in the past interrupted by another action also in the past.

The structure: S+TO BE (PAST) +V+ING

The tense indicators: I was watching TV **when / suddenly** my sister arrived

The past perfect:

It is used to speak about an action that had duration in the past before another action in the past, too.

The structure: S+HAD+ PAST PARTICIPLE

I **had been** a pupil in this primary school for 5 years **before** I **moved** to my secondary school in 2005.

The conditions:

Condition type 1: it is used to speak about a real situation in the present.

IF+ PRESENT → FUTURE (WILL+VERB)

If I study hard, I will succeed

Condition type 2: it is used to speak about unreal present, a hypothetical dream situation, now

IF +PAST → WOULD + VERB

If I had a lot of money, I would buy a big castle

Condition type3: it is used to speak about a past event that did not happen and that now you regret. However, now it's too late and nothing can be done, anymore.

IF+HAD+PAST PARTICIPLE→ WOULD+HAVE+ PAST PARTICIPLE

If I had slept early, I would have arrived on time

Modals:

Can, could, must, have to, had to, shall, should, will, would, ought to, may, might + verb in the bare infinitive (they must be followed by a Verb without "to")

Verbs of perception: love, hate, enjoy, prefer, detest, like, dislike

1- **They are, however, never used in the "ING" form**

2- Must be followed by a NOUN or V+ING